Indian army's chief of eastern command to becoming the COAS), met with the US consul-general in Kolkata and offered Indian expertise in counterinsurgency warfare to help the US efforts in Afghanistan (catching the US embassy in New Delhi by surprise).[90] Such unsubtle Indian attempts to shape the contours of the reconciliation process had limited impact.

Menon confirms that India never accepted the idea the way it was presented by Britain. 'The idea that reconciliation per se, as reconciliation qua reconciliation, is good, we never accepted that idea. We have always accepted the idea that reconciliation [should happen] on certain basic terms such as accepting the Afghan constitution. And that they [Taliban] will have to come back to the mainstream, and that the fighting had to stop', he says.[91] There was a chicken-and-egg problem. Were these aspects to be outcomes or preconditions? For a diverse country riddled by multiple separatist insurgencies such as India, whose policymakers were trained to be constitutionalists, this was a precondition. For the UK, which had fought the Irish for decades, these were outcomes of talks. Menon asked British policymakers, how could they reconcile with somebody who is still carrying weapons, waging war against a state, does not accept the constitution or the legality of the government, and disenfranchises half the country [all the women]? What were they reconciling with? 'We are not saying he [Taliban] has to do it all today, but he has to say today that he will do these in an agreed time frame. [If not], then it's not reconciliation, then its capitulation. Or it's just an agreement that you both negotiated some arrangement amongst yourself and you can give it nice names like reconciliation, but it isn't.'[92]

Manmohan Singh, Prasad, Mukhopadhaya, Chidambaram, and Rakesh Sood were in agreement with Menon. 'We did not accept the British approach towards reconciliation, and still don't think that it will work', said Prasad.[93] Citing examples of Tajikistan and Nepal, both countries with a history of violent insurgencies and where he worked as a diplomat, Prasad thought that the British format of reconciliation did more harm than good. 'Unlike the British who come up with detailed timelines, we [India] don't put pressure on other governments. We let the process take its own time and develop to a position where an internal agreement is reached between fighting parties'.[94] India's position on reconciliation came from its own COIN experience where legitimising the Indian constitution